Lesson 19 material: Grammar: Past Tense Verbs and Forming Questions

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

1.6: Grammar: Past Tense Verbs

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

This lesson is available as a slide presentation.

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Simple Past and Past Continuous

Compare these sentences. What are the verbs? How is the past tense formed in each sentence?

- Cody Gibson studied photography in Oregon and Colorado.
- Cody was studying photography when he decided to change his major.

Answers

- In the first sentence, the verb is "studied," simple past regular verb.
- In the second sentence, the verbs are "was studying" (past continuous) and "decided" (simple past)

Simple Past Form

Regular verbs use base verb + -ed

- EX: Decide--decided

Irregular verbs do not follow one rule

- EX: Find--found
- EX: Eat--eaten

Past Tense Spelling for Regular Verbs (Adding -ed)

- Most regular verbs add -ed to the infinitive form
  - EX: Walk--walked
- Regular verbs ending in -e just add -d
  - EX: Like--liked
  - EX: Receive--received
- CVC Rule: Regular verbs ending in one stressed vowel + one consonant (except w, x, or y) double the consonant and add -ed

    - EX: Plan--planned
    - EX: Stop--stopped
    - EX: Refer--referred
    - EX: Control--controlled
- Regular verbs ending in consonant + y change the y to i and add -ed
    - EX: Carry--carried
    - EX: Study--studied
    - EX: Try--tried
- Regular verbs ending in -c add -ked
    - EX: Picnic--picnicked
    - EX: Traffic--trafficked
- Default: All other regular verbs add -ed
    - Ending in one or more vowels (except final e)
    - EX: Moo--mooed
    - EX: Ski--skied
    - Ending in two or more consonants
    - EX: Depend--depended
    - EX: Push--pushed
    - EX: Start--started
    - Ending in unstressed syllable and one consonant
    - EX: Market--marketed
    - EX: Number--numbered
    - EX: Question--questioned
    - Ending in two or more vowels + one consonant
    - EX: Explain--explained
    - EX: Rain--rained
    - Ending in vowel + y
    - EX: Enjoy--enjoyed
    - EX: Play--played
    - Ending in w or x
    - EX: Show--showed
    - EX: Tax--taxed

Ninety Common Irregular Verbs

Be--was/were--been

Beat--beat--beaten

Become--became--become

Begin--began--begun

Blow--blew--blown

Break--broke--broken

Bring--brought--brought

Build--built--built

Burst--burst--burst

Buy--bought--bought

Catch--caught--caught

Choose--chose--chosen

Come--came--come

Cost--cost--cost

Cut--cut--cut

Deal--dealt--dealt

Do--did--done

Drink--drank--drunk

Drive--drove--driven

Eat--ate--eaten

Forgive--forgave--forgiven

Freeze--froze--frozen

Get--got--got/gotten

Give--gave--given

Go--went--gone

Grow--grew--grown

Have--had--had

Fall--fell--fallen

Feed--fed--fed

Feel--felt--felt

Fight--fought--fought

Find--found--found

Fly--flew--flown

Forbid--forbade--forbidden

Forget--forgot--forgotten

Hear--heard--heard

Hide--hid--hidden

Hit--hit--hit

Hold--held--held

Hurt--hurt--hurt

Keep--kept--kept

Know--knew--known

Lay--laid--laid

Lead--led--led

Leave--left--left

Let--let--let

Lie--lay--lain (be in horizontal position) ("lie" is regular when it means not to tell the truth)

Lose--lost--lost

Make--made--made

Meet--met--met

Pay--paid--paid

Put--put--put

Quit--quit--quit

Read--read--read

Ride--rode--ridden

Ring--rang--rung

Rise--rose--risen

Run--ran--run

Say--said--said

See--saw--seen

Seek--sought--sought

Sell--sold--sold

Send--sent--sent

Shake--shook--shaken

Shine--shone--shone

Sing--sang--sung

Sit--sat--sat

Sleep--slept--slept

Speak--spoke--spoken

Spend--spent--spent

Spring--sprang--sprung

Stand--stood--stood

Steal--stole--stolen

Swim--swam--swum

Swing--swung--swung

Take--took--taken

Teach--taught--taught

Tear--tore--torn

Tell--told--told

Think--thought--thought

Throw--threw--thrown

Understand--understood--understood

Wake--woke--woken

Wear--wore--worn

Win--won--won

Write--wrote--written

More Irregular Verbs

A complete list of irregular verbs may be found here.

Suggested lists for learning irregular verbs may be found here.

Irregular verb flashcards for practice may be found here.

Using Simple Past

Simple past is used for any completed action(s) in the past. The action may be in the recent or distant past. It may be a single or repeated action.

- When he was a child, Cody attended 17 different schools.
- Last week, he got a job with his dream company.

Which sentence talks about an action in the recent past? Which sentence talks about an action in the distant past? Which sentence talks about a repeated action? Which sentence talks about a single action?

Answers

- The second sentence talks about an action in the recent past.
- The first sentence talks about an action in the distant past.
- The first sentence talks about a repeated action.
- The second sentence talks about a single action.

Past Continuous Form

Two ways to describe the form:

- "Be" (past tense) + base verb + -ing
- "Was/were" + present participle

EX: While we were writing a thank you letter, she was sleeping.

Spelling Rules for Adding -ing to a Verb

No change	Most verbs:	Add -ing	Read--reading	Talk--talking	Say--saying	Want--wanting	
No change	Verbs that end in -y:	Add -ing	Study--studying	Carry--carrying	Play--playing		
Change	Verbs that end in -e:	Drop the -e and add -ing	Wake--waking	Make--making	Tape--taping		
Change	Verbs that end in -ie:	Change the -ie to -y	Die--dying	Lie--lying			
Change	Verbs that end in CVC (consonant, vowel, consonant), one syllable:	Double the last letter	Stop--stopping	Sit--sitting	Ban--banning		
Change	Verbs that end in CVC, two syllables:	If the stress is on the last syllable, double the last letter	Begin--beginning	Refer--referring	BUT	Listen--listening	Cancel--canceling

Using Past Continuous

There are two common uses for past continuous form.

Use 1: An action in progress is interrupted by another event or time

- EX: When you arrived, we were writing you a letter
- EX: At 10:00 AM, she was walking around her neighborhood

In the first sentence, which action takes longer? Which action interrupts? In the second sentence, what action was she doing when the clock said 10:00 AM?

Answers

In the first sentence, it takes longer to write. Your arrival interrupted the writing. The interruption is in simple present, the longer action is in past continuous. In the second sentence, she was walking (past continuous) when the clock changed to 10:00 AM (simple past).

Use 2: Two actions in progress at the same time.

- EX: We were reading while the instructor was writing on the board.
- EX: While she was walking around the neighborhood, she was getting fresh air and exercise.

In the first sentence, which action took longer, reading or writing? In the second sentence, which action took longer, walking or getting?

Answers

In the first sentence, reading and writing happened at the same time. We don't know which one took longer. In the second sentence, walking and getting fresh air happened at the same time. They both started and ended at the same time.

Videos

Watch this video to learn about the simple past tense.

Watch this video to learn about the difference between simple and continuous past.

Watch this video and this video to learn more about the past continuous form.

Practice the Past Tenses

An achievement is the act of reaching a goal. Examples of achievements include:

- Completing a difficult class
- Earning a degree
- Getting a job
- Finding an apartment
- Saving enough money to buy a house or car
- Raising a healthy family
- Learning to cook a special dish

Think of two more examples with your classmates.

When we achieve a goal, we feel proud. Write a list of three achievements that make you feel proud.

Choose one achievement and write a paragraph about it. Describe all the steps you took to achieve your goal. What was difficult about achieving your goal?

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1.7: Grammar: Forming Questions

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Forming Yes/No Questions with a Main Verb

Compare these sentences...

- In 2007, Felipe Valdez moved to the United States to pursue his education
- Since 2007, he has completed his bachelor's degree
- He is pursuing his career as an intern at NASA

What are the verbs? What is the tense of each verb? What is the aspect of each verb? What are the auxiliaries for each verb? Remember, tense = past, present, future, aspect = simple, continuous, perfect, and auxiliary = be, have, do...

Answers

- In the first sentence, the verb is "moved," the aspect is simple, the tense is past, and there is no auxiliary
- In the second sentence, the verb is "had completed," the tense is present, the aspect is perfect, and the auxiliary is "have"
- In the third sentence, the verb is "is pursuing," the tense is present, the aspect is continuous, and the auxiliary is "be"

Compare these questions. Identify the auxiliary, main verb, and subject...

- Did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.?
- Has he completed his bachelor's degree?
- Is he pursuing his career?

What order do the auxiliary, main verb, and subject follow? What form does each take? What is the rule for forming yes/no questions with a main verb?

Answers

- In the first sentence, the auxiliary is "did," the main verb is "move," and the subject is "Felipe Valdez;" "move" is the base form, used with simple aspect
- In the second sentence, the auxiliary is "has," the main verb is "completed," and the subject is "he;" "completed" is the past participle, used with perfect present

- In the third sentence, the auxiliary is "is," the main verb is "pursuing," and the subject is "he;" "pursuing" is the present participle, used with continuous aspect

The auxiliary, subject, and main verb follow this order: aux + subject + verb with aspect

They take the following forms: aux has the tense and main verb has the aspect

The rule for forming yes/no questions with a main verb is as follows: aux + subject + verb with aspect + complement

Forming Yes/No Questions with "Be"

Compare these sentences...

- Felipe Valdez attended University of California, Sacramento
- He was an excellent student
- He was studying mechanical engineering

What is the verb in each sentence?

Answers

- The verb is "attended"
- The verb is "was"
- The verb is "was studying"

Compare these questions...

- Did he attend UC Sacramento?
- Is he an excellent student?
- Was he studying mechanical engineering?

What is the auxiliary verb in each? What is the main verb in each?

Answers

- The auxiliary is "did," the main verb is "attend"
- The main verb is "are" (be)
- The auxiliary is "be," the main verb is "studying"

Rule: When the main verb is "be," use "be" in the same position as the auxiliary; aux + subject + complement. When the main verb is not "be," use an auxiliary to create a question. Auxiliary verbs are "do," "be," and "have"...

Forming Information Questions with a Main Verb

Compare these questions. How are they different?

- Did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.?
- When did Felipe Valdez move to the U.S.?
- Was he studying mechanical engineering?
- Where was he studying mechanical engineering?

Which questions ask for the answer "yes" or "no?" Which questions ask for more information? Do the auxiliary, subject, and verb follow the same order in information questions as they do in yes/no questions?

Answers

The first sentence in each pair asks for the answer "yes" or "no." The second question in each pair asks for more information. Yes, the auxiliary, subject, and verb follow the same order in information questions as they do in yes/no questions

What is the Pattern for Information Questions?

Wh + aux + subject + verb with aspect + complement. This pattern works for all tenses

Check the pattern above on the questions below...

- When was he studying mechanical engineering?
- Where did he complete his bachelor's degree?
- How did he design the space vehicle controls?
- Why has he become an intern at NASA?

Questions About the Subject

Questions about the subject follow a different pattern

- Scientists have studied space for many years

Compare the two questions. What is the answer to each question?

- Who has studied space for many years?
- What have scientists studied for many years?

What is the question order in the first question? What is the question order in the second question?

Answers

- The answer to the first question is "scientists"
- The answer to the second question is "space"

The question order in the first question is "who/what" + verb (with tense/aspect in third singular) + complement

The question order in the second sentence is wh + auxiliary + subject + verb (with aspect)

Here is another example...

- The scientists warned the mayor about the meteor

Compare these two questions. What is the answer to each question?

- Who warned the mayor about the meteor?
- Who did the scientists warn about the meteor?

Which question is asking about the subject? What is the question word order in each question?

Answers

- The answer to the first question is "scientists"
- The answer to the second question is "the mayor"

The first question is asking about the subject. The word order in the first question is "who/what" + verb (with tense/aspect in third singular) + complement and the word order in the second question is wh + auxiliary + subject + verb (with aspect)

Questions with a Noun Phrase in the Question Word

Some questions have the subject or object in the question word. These include "how many _____," "how much _____," "what kind of _____," and "which _____"

Compare these sentences...

- How many students are attending UC Sacramento?
- How many awards has Felipe won?

Which question has a question word as the subject? Which question has a question word as an object? Does the verb always agree with the subject?

Answers

The first question has a question word as the subject. The second question has a question word as an object. Yes, the verb always agrees with the subject

Key Takeaways

- Auxiliary words are "do," "be," "have," and modals
- Question words are "who," "what," "when," "where," "why," and "how"
- Tenses are past, present, and future
- Verb with aspects means:
  - Continuous: verb + -ing (present participle)
  - Simple: base form
  - Perfect: past participle
- Yes/no questions will use the order: aux + subject + verb with aspect
- Information questions will use the order wh + auxiliary + subject + verb with aspect
- Questions about the subject are the exception. They use:
  - "Who/what" + verb with tense and aspect + complement

Videos and Other Resources

Watch this video and this video for more information about forming questions in English...

Still not sure about subject questions? Try this video and written explanation...

Practice Question Formation

Write questions about the profile below...

Leslie Reynolds began as a law enforcement ranger in Yosemite National Park. Then she went on to work at Grand Canyon and Shenandoah National Parks, serving these parks as an officer, medic, instructor, investigator, and even counselor. She has stepped up in many life-saving situations in her 21-year career; she has helped save hikers suffering from heat exhaustion in the Grand Canyon, injured climbers stuck and needing helicopter rescue, and victims of serious motor vehicle accidents. Because she understands that prevention and education is effective in saving lives, Reynolds helped develop the Preventative Search & Rescue (PSAR) programs at Yosemite and Shenandoah National Parks. She has also served as a member of the Critical Incident Stress Management Team, responding to numerous major traumatic events and helping team members cope with what they have been through and seen. As the current chief ranger at Cape Cod National Seashore, Reynolds continues to inspire the new generation of park rangers and lead through example.

- Leslie Reynolds began her career at Yosemite National Park
  - Where...
- Leslie Reynolds worked as an officer, medic, instructor, investigator, and counselor
  - How many jobs...
- Leslie has helped save hikers, climbers, and accident victims
  - Who...
- Because she understands the importance of prevention and education, Leslie developed the PSAR programs
  - Why...
- Leslie has worked for the National Park Service for 21 years
  - How long...

Answers

- Where did Leslie Reynolds begin her career?
- How many jobs did Leslie Reynolds do?
- Who has Leslie helped save?
- Why did Leslie develop the PSAR programs?
- How long has Leslie worked for the National Park Service?

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4.3: Past Tense Practice: Dictogloss Activity

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For the Instructor

Choose a short reading below. Read and discuss the pre-reading questions with the class. Then read the text slowly. Address student questions about unfamiliar vocabulary. Read the text at least three times. Ask students to take notes on the second or third time through.

Students write a summary of the text, using the correct verb tense. You may have students write individual summaries, then share with a partner, or work in pairs or groups to write a summary. Ask pairs or groups to share their product. Classmates can listen and make corrections, especially in verb tense.

Short Reading 1

Read three times; students take notes then summarize...

Pre-reading Questions

- Do women have the right to vote in the U.S.? In your country? When did women win this right?
- Do you think there should be more women in politics? Why or why not?

Text

Jeannette Rankin was born on June 11, 1880. Her parents were John and Olive Rankin. She grew up in Montana and graduated from the University of Montana in 1902. After she graduated, she worked for women's right to vote in Washington State and Montana. She stayed in the congress for one term. She ran for congress again in 1940 and won. She was a pacifist. This means she was against war and believed the U.S. should not participate in any war. She voted against the U.S. joining World War 1 in 1917 and World War 2 in 1941. She was the only congressperson who voted against joining World War 2.

Short Reading 2

Read three times; students take notes then summarize...

Pre-reading Questions

- What do you know about climate change?
- Who are some famous climate change activists?
- What do climate change activists do?

Text

Greta Thunberg is a leader in the movement against climate change. She was born on January 3, 2002 in Sweden. In 2018, she began spending her school days outside the Swedish parliament. She held a sign that said "School strike for climate." She wanted them to take stronger action to stop climate change. At first, she was alone, but soon, other students joined her protests. Together, they organized a school climate strike called Fridays for the Future.

Thunberg addressed the United Nations Climate Change Conference in 2018. Students began striking every week around the world. In 2019, millions of students protested around the world, asking for stronger action to stop the climate crisis.

In May 2019, *Time* magazine showed Thunberg on their cover. They called her the person of the year. In September 2019, she addressed the UN Climate Action Summit in New York. She was also nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize in 2019.

Short Reading 3

Read three times; students take notes then summarize...

Pre-reading Questions

- Have you ever swum in the ocean?
- What are some dangers of swimming in the ocean?
- What is the farthest a human can swim?

Alternative Pre-reading

Diana Nyad's TED talk is available here...

Text

Diana Nyad is the first person to swim from Havana, Cuba to Florida without a shark cage. She swam 110 miles (180 kilometers) and fifty-three hours. She was 64 years old when she accomplished her goal.

How did she do it?

Nyad attempted the swim five times from 2010 to 2013 and did not succeed until her fifth try in 2013. Each time she tried, she had to stop because of storms, jellyfish stings, asthma, and shoulder pain. On Sept. 2, 2013, she reached her goal despite these setbacks.

She trained by swimming eight to fourteen hours in the ocean every other week. While she was training, she gathered a team of about 35 people. These people helped her while she was swimming. One person paddled beside her in a kayak and used a device to keep sharks away from her. Others helped her put on a suit to keep jellyfish from stinging her. In order to help her swim in a straight line, her team dragged a streamer during the day and LED lights at night behind a boat and she followed them. To keep her mind busy while she was swimming, she thought about books and movies, counted, and sang.

When asked about her motivation, she answered, "Because I'd like to prove to the other 60-year-olds that it is never too late to start your dreams."

(Picture: File:Diana Nyad routes.jpg - Wikimedia Commons)

Figure: Nyad's Havana to Key West swimming routes since 1978

Links on the original page

- TED talk: https://www.ted.com/talks/diana_nyad_never_ever_give_up